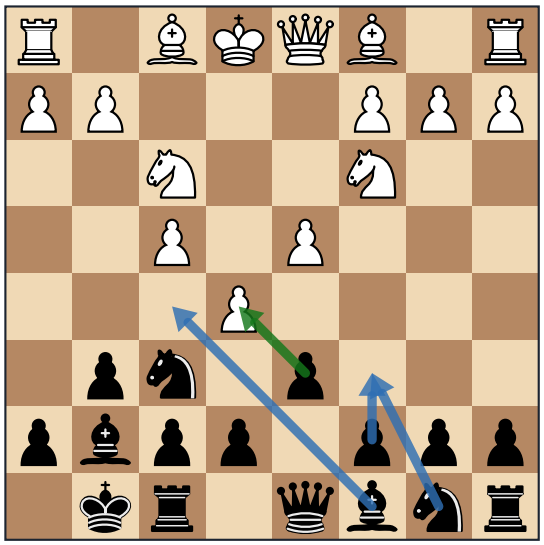
Pirc Defense

ECO B00-B09 | 28 named lines | Semi-open / hypermodern defenses

In one sentence: Hypermodern and semi-open defenses avoid book fights: Black lets White build, then counterattacks the center.

Memory pattern: Let White build, then hit the center with ...c5 or ...e5.



Main line: 1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.f4 Bg7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.e5

Key ideas

1. Black fianchettoes (Pirc/Modern) or hits e4 at once (Scandinavian, Alekhine).
2. White gets space and often a big center, but it can become a target.
3. Black's key breaks are ...c5, ...e5 and ...f5 at the right moment.
4. Develop quickly and avoid early queen moves unless they win time.
5. White should avoid overextension and keep pieces coordinated.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.30** (slightly better for White, depth 17). Best: dxe5.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Black avoids symmetrical development: a fianchetto (Pirc/Modern), a quick ...d5 (Scandinavian) or tempo play (Alekhine). White often gets a big center.
2. Where does my king go?	Black castles short behind the fianchetto; White often attacks with f4/Be3/Qd2/h4.
3. Best minor pieces?	Black: Bg7, Nf6/Nd7, ...c5/...e5 breaks. White: Nc3, Nf3, Be3, Bc4.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Black waits, then undermines the center with ...c5 or ...e5; White consolidates the center and develops quickly.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants a big center and a fast attack; Black wants to hit the center in time.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.f4 Bg7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.e5

Move	Why it is played
1. e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... d6	Support. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
2. d4	Take the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
2... Nf6	Hit e4. Develops the knight to f6.
3. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
3... g6	Fianchetto. Gains space on the wing.
4. f4	Austrian attack. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4... Bg7	Long diagonal. Fianchetto: the bishop takes the long diagonal.
5. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
5... O-O	Castles: the king reaches safety and the rook joins the center.
6. e5	Occupies the center with a pawn.



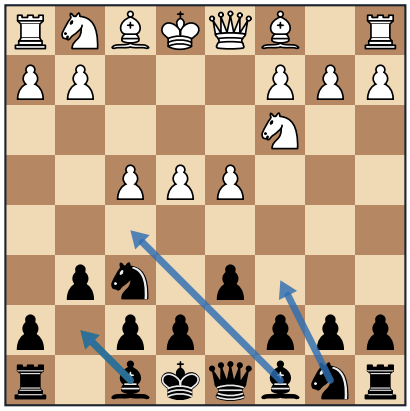
After 1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6



After Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.f4 Bg7

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

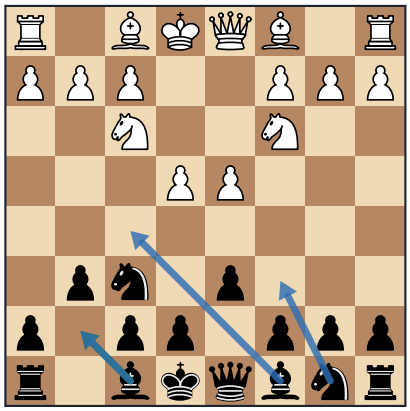


Position after the line

Austrian Attack B09 | 8 lines

`1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.f4`

Stockfish: **+0.59** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: Bg7.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Unzicker Attack, Dragon Formation, Kurajica Variation, Ljubojevic Variation

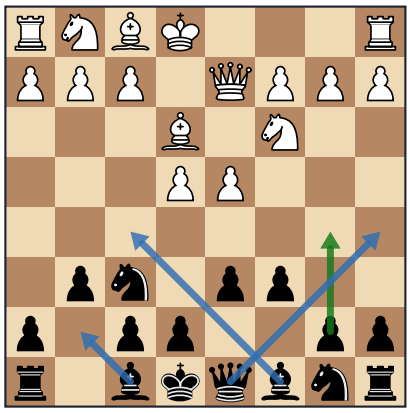


Position after the line

Classical Variation B08 | 7 lines

`1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Nf3`

Stockfish: **+0.59** (slightly better for White, depth 14). Best next move: Bg7.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Quiet System, Schlechter Variation

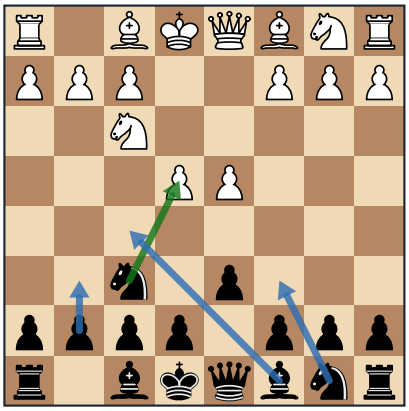


Position after the line

150 Attack B07 | 3 lines

`1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Be3 c6 5.Qd2`

Stockfish: **+0.68** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: b5.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Inner Doll Defense, Sveshnikov-Jansa Attack

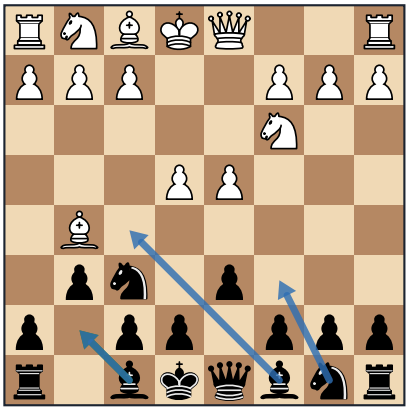


Position after the line

Roscher Gambit B00 | 1 lines

`1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nf3`

Stockfish: **-0.78** (clearly better for Black, depth 17). Best next move: Nxe4.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)

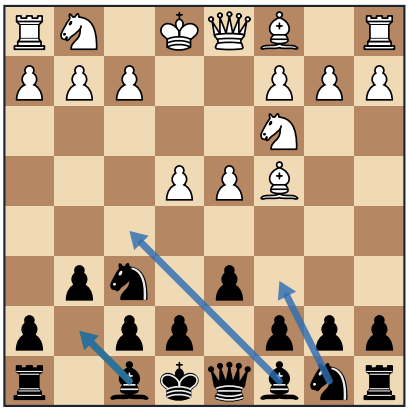


Position after the line

Byrne Variation B07 | 1 lines

`1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Bg5`

Stockfish: **+0.71** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Bg7.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)



Position after the line

Kholmov System B07 | 1 lines

`1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Bc4`

Stockfish: **+0.34** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: Bg7.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)

Detailed repertoire notes

Pirc Defense (B07-B09, Black)

`1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Be2 O-O 6.O-O c6 7.a4 Nbd7 8.Be3 e5 9.dxe5 dxe5 10.Bg5`

Idea: Fianchetto and counterattack the center with ...c5 or ...e5.

Structure: Hypermodern structure: White e4/d4 vs Black d6/g6/Bg7. Black counterattacks with ...c5, ...e5.

Pieces: Bg7 is the key piece; knights d7/f6, queen c7/b6.

Plan: Complete development, castle, and strike with ...e5 or ...c5. Against the Austrian Attack, strike with ...c5.

King: Castle early behind the fianchetto; avoid ...h6. **Opponent:** A big center (e4-d4-f4) and Bc4/Be3/Qd2/h4 attack; counter with ...c5 or ...e5.

Watch out: The Austrian Attack (4.f4) and 150 Attack are sharp; know your lines.

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Know the move-order tricks: in the Pirc, White's Austrian Attack (f4) is the main danger; in the Scandinavian, learn the queen retreat squares (a5, d6, d8). Always counterattack the center within the first 8-10 moves.

Why play it

Hypermodern and semi-open defenses avoid book fights: Black lets White build, then counterattacks the center.

Typical mistakes

- Letting White roll forward with e5 and f4 without a counter-break.
- Moving the queen repeatedly in the Scandinavian and falling behind in development.
- Fianchettoing without castling early and leaving the king exposed.

Typical tactics and traps

- Bxf7+ or Bxh7+ if Black's king sits behind a fianchetto without defenders.
- e5 forks or pins after Black ignores the center.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Black aims to undermine White's center and reach an equal middlegame with flexible pawn structure.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Pirc Defense (all lines)** — B00
  `1.e4 d6`
  - **Roscher Gambit** — B00
    `1.e4 d6 -> 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nf3`
  - **Austrian Attack** — B09
    `1.e4 d6 -> 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.f4`
    - **Ljubojevic Variation** — B09
      `1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.f4 -> 4...Bg7 5.Bc4`
    - **Dragon Formation** — B09
      `1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.f4 -> 4...Bg7 5.Nf3 c5`
    - **Kurajica Variation** — B09
      `1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.f4 -> 4...Bg7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.Be3`
    - **Unzicker Attack** — B09
      `1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.f4 -> 4...Bg7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.e5`
      - **Bronstein Variation** — B09
        `1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.f4 Bg7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.e5 -> 6...Nfd7 7.h4`
    - **Weiss Variation** — B09
      `1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.f4 -> 4...Bg7 5.Nf3 O-O 6.Bd3`
  - **Byrne Variation** — B07
    `1.e4 d6 -> 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Bg5`
  - **Classical Variation** — B08
    `1.e4 d6 -> 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Nf3`
    - **Quiet System** — B08
      `1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Nf3 -> 4...Bg7 5.Be2`
      - **Chigorin Line** — B08
        `1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Be2 -> 5...O-O 6.O-O Nc6`
      - **Czech Defense** — B08
        `1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Be2 -> 5...O-O 6.O-O c6`
      - **Parma Defense** — B08
        `1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Nf3 Bg7 5.Be2 -> 5...O-O 6.O-O Bg4`
    - **Schlechter Variation** — B08
      `1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Nf3 -> 4...Bg7 5.h3`
  - **Kholmov System** — B07
    `1.e4 d6 -> 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Bc4`
  - **Sveshnikov System** — B07
    `1.e4 d6 -> 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.g3`
  - **150 Attack** — B07
    `1.e4 d6 -> 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Be3 c6 5.Qd2`
    - **Sveshnikov-Jansa Attack** — B07
      `1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Be3 c6 5.h3`
    - **Inner Doll Defense** — B07
      `1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Be3 c6 5.Qd2 -> 5...Bg4`
  - **Bayonet Attack** — B07
    `1.e4 d6 -> 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Be2 Bg7 5.h4`
  - **Chinese Variation** — B07
    `1.e4 d6 -> 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.Be2 Bg7 5.g4`

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.e4 d6 2.d4 Nf6 3.Nc3 g6 4.f4 Bg7 5.Nf3 0-0
```

Plan chain

White	Nc3 -> Nf3 -> d4 -> Bd2 -> Bc4
Black	Nf6 -> g6 -> Bg7 -> d6 -> c6

Three rules to remember

1. Let White build, then hit the center with ...c5 or ...e5.

2. Black waits, then undermines the center with ...c5 or ...e5; White consolidates the center and develops quickly.

3. White wants a big center and a fast attack; Black wants to hit the center in time.

Pawn structure in one line

Black avoids symmetrical development: a fianchetto (Pirc/Modern), a quick ...d5 (Scandinavian) or tempo play (Alekhine). White often gets a big center.